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Definitions

BFS (Builders FirstSource) – BLDR.com, NYSE:BLDR, a U.S. building-products and services company. BFS manufactures structural framing, distributes lumber and building materials, and partners with builders across North America. When this knowledge article cites BFS documents, it reflects publicly available information and does not include any proprietary data.

Introduction & Why Sustainability Matters in Building Products

The building and construction sector is responsible for significant material consumption and greenhouse-gas emissions. Using responsibly sourced materials like wood helps reduce embodied carbon while maintaining performance. Wood products contain **biogenic carbon**—carbon sequestered from the atmosphere and stored in the material. In contrast, **embodied carbon** refers to the greenhouse-gas emissions released during material extraction, manufacturing, transport, construction and disposal ¹. Life-cycle assessment (LCA) quantifies these impacts across the product's life cycle, and **Environmental Product Declarations (EPDs)** serve as “material nutrition labels” that report the carbon footprint ². Choosing certified wood from forests managed to rigorous environmental standards and tracking supply chains helps builders achieve sustainability goals and earn credits in green-building rating systems.

BuildersFirstSource (BFS) emphasises sustainability in its corporate strategy. According to the company's 2025 corporate social responsibility (CSR) report, **approximately 89% of the wood sold by BFS comes from Sustainable Forestry Initiative (SFI) or Forest Stewardship Council (FSC) certified suppliers** ³. The company also highlights that **manufactured framing components have avoided more than 7.5 million trees since 2019** ³ and have avoided 211 k metric tons of CO₂e emissions by reducing waste ⁴. These practices illustrate how sourcing certified wood and optimising manufacturing can lower the environmental footprint of building projects.

Major Certifications (FSC, SFI, PEFC, LEED, etc.)

Tree-of-thought overview

When evaluating material certifications, decision-makers should consider **what type of certification**, **where it applies** (region), and **which product lines it covers** (lumber, engineered components, panels, packaging). The following branches can guide material selection:

1. **Certification body** – FSC, SFI, Programme for the Endorsement of Forest Certification (PEFC), Sustainable Lumber Initiative (regional schemes). Each has different governance and stakeholder participation ⁵ ⁶ .
2. **Region** – Many countries operate under PEFC-endorsed standards (e.g., CSA in Canada), whereas FSC and SFI are widely used in North America. LEED credits apply in the U.S. and internationally, but projects in different regions may use alternative rating systems such as BREEAM.
3. **Product line** – Solid lumber, engineered wood (I-joists, LVL), mass timber panels, structural components, moulding, interior finishes or packaging. Certification ensures that each product in the supply chain meets chain-of-custody requirements.

Certification landscape

Certification	Scope	Key requirements	Typical premium
FSC® (Forest Stewardship Council)	Independent, non-profit global program with ~180 million ha certified ⁵ ; focuses on ecological and social values.	Requires compliance with all standards; on-the-ground monitoring; public reporting; multi-stakeholder standard setting ⁶ . Criteria include legality, community relations, environmental impact, comprehensive management plans and monitoring of forest operations ⁷ .	Certification cost small; owner pays annual fee; requires investment; management planning; chain-of-custody; infrastructure ⁸ . FSC-certified products sometimes command premium to ≥2% though competitive markets may be no premium ⁹ .

Certification	Scope	Key requirements	Typical premium
SFI® (Sustainable Forestry Initiative)	North American program developed by the American Forest & Paper Association; ~280 million ha certified through SFI and PEFC programs ⁶ .	Requires sustainable forestry practices, best management practices to protect water quality, legal compliance, community engagement and continuous improvement ⁷ . Less stringent public accountability; monitoring is optional and reporting focuses on progress, not strict compliance ⁵ .	Costs are generally higher than FSC, but can add to product price chain-requirements ¹⁰ .
PEFC® (Programme for the Endorsement of Forest Certification)	Umbrella organisation recognising national standards (e.g., SFI in the U.S., CSA in Canada). Largest scheme with ~280 million ha certified ⁶ .	Emphasises bottom-up governance; certification is often conducted by second-party organisations; recognised in many European and Asian markets ⁶ . Requirements are similar to SFI but may vary by country.	Premiums are comparable to SFI; chain-requirements are required, but costs are lower due to

Certification	Scope	Key requirements	Typical premium
LEED® (Leadership in Energy and Environmental Design)	U.S. Green Building Council rating system for buildings. LEED 2009 offered a point under Materials & Resources credit 7 for projects that used ≥ 50 % FSC-certified wood ¹¹ . LEED v4 counts certified wood under the Building Product Disclosure & Optimization – Sourcing of Raw Materials credit if products meeting responsible sourcing criteria compose ≥ 25 % of permanently installed products ¹¹ .	Documentation must include invoices showing FSC claims (e.g., FSC Mix xx % counted at the proportion of FSC content) and chain-of-custody certificates ¹² . SFI materials do not currently earn LEED credits.	There is a direct premium for obtaining credit, sourcing certified wood can add a similar premium.

Certification comparison

The Institute for Agriculture & Trade Policy notes that **FSC** is an independent non-profit governed by multiple stakeholders and requires full compliance with strict standards ⁵ . **SFI** is run by industry and emphasises continuous improvement rather than strict compliance, with less public accountability ⁵ . **PEFC** recognises national schemes and is considered more flexible than FSC, though some environmental groups regard FSC as the gold standard. When specifying wood, the choice may depend on project goals (e.g., LEED credits require FSC), regional availability and client preferences.

How BFS Sources Certified Wood (percentages & practices)

Progress over time

BFS reports a consistent increase in sourcing certified wood:

- **2023** – The company announced that **over 90 % of its wood supply came from SFI or FSC certified vendors** ¹³ and that >1.3 million trees were saved through the use of manufactured framing components in 2022 ¹³ .
- **2024** – BFS stated that **more than 95 % of its wood was sourced from SFI/FSC certified vendors** and that >1.5 million trees were saved through manufactured products in 2023 ¹⁴ . The company also obtained **FSC chain-of-custody certification for all distribution centres**, enabling it to sell FSC-certified material on a broker basis ¹⁵ .
- **2025** – The CSR report indicates that **about 89 % of wood sold through BFS comes from SFI/FSC certified suppliers** ³ (the percentage dropped slightly due to changes in supply mix), yet the company continues emphasising that certified wood is its primary wood offering ⁴ .

Supply chain practices

1. **Primary sourcing** – BFS procures lumber and engineered wood from mills certified under SFI and FSC programs and ensures that shipments are accompanied by chain-of-custody certificates. This documentation verifies the origin and allows customers to claim LEED credits when applicable ¹².
2. **Manufactured components** – BFS manufactures roof trusses, floor trusses and wall panels in controlled environments. By designing precisely and optimising cuts, these facilities reduce waste. According to BFS, the use of manufactured components has saved millions of trees since 2019 ³ and avoided hundreds of thousands of metric tons of CO₂e ⁴.
3. **Chain-of-custody and traceability** – In 2024, BFS achieved FSC chain-of-custody certification for all distribution centres ¹⁵. This allows BFS to act as a broker of FSC-certified materials, ensuring that customers receive products with the appropriate FSC claims and that the chain of custody remains intact from forest to job site.
4. **Continuous improvement** – BFS regularly audits suppliers and tracks the percentage of certified wood. It participates in industry initiatives and monitors regulatory changes to ensure compliance with evolving standards.

Lifecycle Assessment & Embodied Carbon in Wood Products

Understanding embodied and biogenic carbon

Life-cycle assessment (LCA) evaluates the environmental impacts of a product from raw-material extraction through manufacturing, transport, use and end-of-life. **Embodied carbon** is the sum of greenhouse-gas emissions across these stages ¹. **Biogenic carbon** is carbon stored in biomass; wood products keep carbon locked up for decades in buildings ¹. Wood manufacturing often requires less energy than steel or concrete and can use waste wood as fuel, resulting in lower embodied emissions ¹.

LCA tools and EPDs

EPDs are independently verified documents that disclose environmental impacts, including global warming potential, for specific products ². Many jurisdictions now require EPDs when procuring materials for public projects ¹⁶, and the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) is developing a low-carbon materials label to help identify products with substantially lower embodied carbon ¹⁷. Tools like **WoodWorks' carbon calculator** allow designers to compare the carbon stored and avoided by using wood instead of more carbon-intensive materials ¹.

Implications for BFS products

By supplying wood from sustainably managed forests and manufacturing precision-engineered components, BFS helps builders reduce embodied carbon. The biogenic carbon stored in wood continues to count toward a building's carbon budget as long as the material remains in use. Selecting materials with EPDs allows builders to quantify carbon impacts and align with **Buy Clean** initiatives, which are increasingly required in federal and state procurement ¹⁶.

Trends & Market Demand (consumer & regulatory)

Market growth

The global green-building materials market was valued at **US\$285.89 billion in 2024** and is projected to reach **US\$458.61 billion by 2030**, a compound annual growth rate of about **8.5%** ¹⁸. North America accounted for 31.2% of this market, with growth driven by environmental awareness, government incentives and corporate sustainability commitments ¹⁸.

Regulatory momentum

Governments are promoting low-carbon materials through **Buy Clean** policies. The U.S. Federal Buy Clean Initiative, launched in 2021, seeks to reduce embodied carbon in federally funded projects and incentivise the use of low-carbon concrete, steel and other materials ¹⁹. States such as New York, Washington and California require environmental product declarations and set emission limits for materials; New York aims for a **30% reduction in concrete emissions by 2028** ¹⁹. Private companies, including Microsoft and Amazon, are piloting low-carbon concrete and committing to reduce embodied emissions ²⁰.

Consumer and client expectations

Homebuyers and commercial developers increasingly prioritise sustainability. Builders who use certified wood, document their supply chains and report embodied carbon can differentiate their projects and meet code requirements. BFS's ability to supply SFI/FSC-certified lumber and provide chain-of-custody documentation positions it to serve customers seeking green-building certifications.

Innovation Possibilities via SCAMPER

SCAMPER is a creative framework (Substitute, Combine, Adapt, Modify, Put to another use, Eliminate, Reverse) for generating new ideas. Possible innovations related to sustainable materials include:

- **Substitute** – Use mass-timber products (cross-laminated timber, glued-laminated beams) in place of concrete or steel to reduce embodied carbon and store more biogenic carbon.
- **Combine** – Pair **certified wood** with **digital labelling** or QR codes that link to EPDs and chain-of-custody certificates, making it easy for builders to verify sustainability claims.
- **Adapt** – Implement **blockchain traceability** systems to record each step of the supply chain, ensuring that certified wood remains segregated and authentic.
- **Modify** – Redesign packaging and transport logistics using returnable or reusable pallettes to minimise waste and reduce packaging emissions.
- **Put to another use** – Reuse off-cuts and waste wood as feedstock for engineered wood components or as biomass for energy, increasing resource efficiency.
- **Eliminate** – Reduce waste through **lean manufacturing** and just-in-time deliveries; eliminate unnecessary packaging materials or switch to recyclable alternatives.
- **Reverse** – Reconsider the end-of-life phase; design building components for disassembly so that lumber and engineered wood can be reused or recycled at the end of the building's life, closing the loop.

Likely User Questions

When engaging with sustainability and materials topics, customers frequently ask:

- **What is FSC certification?** The FSC (Forest Stewardship Council) is an independent, non-profit organisation that sets rigorous environmental and social standards for forest management and chain of custody ⁵.
- **What percentage of BFS's wood is certified?** According to BFS's 2025 CSR report, ~89 % of wood sold through BFS comes from SFI or FSC certified vendors ³ ⁴; earlier reports indicated >90 % in 2023 ¹³ and >95 % in 2024 ¹⁴.
- **Do green building codes require certified wood?** LEED 2009 offered a point for using ≥ 50 % FSC-certified wood and LEED v4 awards credit if products with responsible sourcing (e.g., FSC) compose ≥ 25 % of permanently installed materials ¹¹. SFI products do not currently earn LEED credits, though they may contribute to other certifications (e.g., Green Globes).
- **What are the costs of certification?** FSC certification can cost small landowners more than US\$5 k annually ⁸ and may add 0–20 % to product prices ⁹; SFI/PEFC certification may have lower costs but still adds around 10–20 % due to chain-of-custody requirements ¹⁰.
- **How does certified wood reduce embodied carbon?** Wood stores biogenic carbon and generally has lower embodied emissions than steel or concrete ¹. Selecting certified wood ensures forests are managed sustainably and supply chains are transparent.

Related Topics / Crosslinks

- **Carbon Accounting & EPDs** – Explore how life-cycle assessment and environmental product declarations support carbon reporting for building products.
- **Circular Economy & Design for Disassembly** – Investigate strategies for designing buildings so that materials can be reused or recycled at end of life.
- **Mass Timber & Engineered Wood** – Learn about cross-laminated timber (CLT), laminated veneer lumber (LVL) and other engineered wood products that enable taller, lighter structures.
- **Supply Chain Traceability** – Examine technologies (blockchain, digital twins) that improve transparency and ensure chain-of-custody compliance.
- **Green Building Rating Systems** – Compare LEED, Green Globes, WELL and other standards to understand credit opportunities for certified materials.

¹ A Carbon Explainer - APA – The Engineered Wood Association
<https://www.apawood.org/a-carbon-explainer>

² Embodied Carbon 101: Building Materials - RMI
<https://rmi.org/embodied-carbon-101/>

³ Builders FirstSource, Inc. - Builders FirstSource Releases 2025 Corporate Social Responsibility Report
<https://investors.blldr.com/news/news-details/2025/Builders-FirstSource-Releases-2025-Corporate-Social-Responsibility-Report/default.aspx>

⁴ Builders FirstSource, Inc. - Corporate Social Responsibility Overview
<https://investors.blldr.com/CSR/>

5 **FSC_vs_SFI_Certification_at_a_Glance.pdf**

https://www.iatp.org/sites/default/files/FSC_vs_SFI_Certification_at_a_Glance.pdf

6 10 **PEFC vs. FSC Certification: What's The Difference?**

<https://duffieldtimber.com/the-workbench/buyers-guides/pefc-vs-fsc-differences>

7 **Key Differences Between FSC and SFI Certifications**

<https://goldenwestpackaging.com/wp/key-differences-between-fsc-and-sfi-certifications/>

8 **Sustainability Forest Certification – Forest Landowners**

<https://forestlandowners.com/sustainability/sustainability-forest-certification/>

9 **What's the Premium for FSC?**

<https://www.buildwithfsc.org/post/what-s-the-premium-for-fsc>

11 12 **FAQs for Green Building**

<https://us.fsc.org/en-us/market/green-building/faqs-for-green-building>

13 **Builders FirstSource, Inc. - Builders FirstSource Releases 2023 Corporate Social Responsibility Report**

<https://investors.blr.com/news/news-details/2023/Builders-FirstSource-Releases-2023-Corporate-Social-Responsibility-Report/default.aspx>

14 **Builders FirstSource Releases 2024 Corporate Social Responsibility Report**

<https://www.businesswire.com/news/home/20240501047993/en/Builders-FirstSource-Releases-2024-Corporate-Social-Responsibility-Report>

15 **Builders FirstSource earns FSC certification | Woodworking Network**

<https://www.woodworkingnetwork.com/news/woodworking-industry-news/builders-firstsource-earns-fsc-certification>

16 19 20 **White House announces new decarbonization commitments | One Click LCA**

<https://oneclicklca.com/en-us/resources/articles/white-house-announces-new-decarbonization-commitments>

17 **Reducing Embodied Carbon of Construction Materials | US EPA**

<https://www.epa.gov/greenerproducts/reducing-embodied-carbon>

18 **Green Building Materials Market Size | Industry Report, 2030**

<https://www.grandviewresearch.com/industry-analysis/green-building-materials-market>